

Oakwood Fund Management

Everything you need to know - explained from zero -
and how to answer what they will ask you.

YOUR INTERVIEW

When	Monday 5 October 2026
Time	10-minute slot between 6:30 and 8:40 pm
Where	New Sci 0.09 (on the left as you enter)
Wear	Smart clothes
Contact	Alex Caesar-Giles - A.Caesar-Giles@uea.ac.uk

INSIDE

- 1 Oakwood in 60 seconds
- 2 What is a student investment fund?
- 3 History & structure
- 4 The money & the portfolio
- 5 Sponsors, partners & reputation
- 6 What you'd actually do
- 7 Where people go after
- 8 The core purpose
- 9 The interview, decoded
- 10 Commercial awareness pack
- 11 Finance quick-fire & character Qs
- 12 Questions to ask + checklist

SECTION 1

Oakwood in 60 seconds

If you only read one page, read this one.

In one sentence: Oakwood Fund Management is UEA's student-run investment fund.

Students split into sector teams, research real companies, pitch which shares to buy or sell, and manage a real pot of money (about £43,000) - so they learn to think like professional investors and get the CV and network to land finance jobs.

2020

Founded in July 2020 by UEA student Michael Prinz (now at Goldman Sachs)

≈ £43k

Real money invested - £43,439 across 38 holdings (per the fund's website)

7

Sector divisions - Tech, Financials, Healthcare, Commodities, Industrials, Consumer, Quant

79+

Reports, valuation models & stock pitches published since 2020

42

Firms & institutions alumni have joined - Goldman, JPM, Deloitte, PwC, HM Treasury...

2 + 1

Two stock-pitch nights and one full industry report per team, every year

The five things to remember

- **It's a fund, not a society.** Oakwood says this itself. Members are expected to produce work "that would stand up in a professional setting". Showing you get this difference is a quick win.
- **It's long-only, equity-focused and historically ESG-led.** It buys shares (it doesn't short-sell), mostly US-listed on the NASDAQ and NYSE, and it has always described itself as an ESG (Environmental, Social, Governance) fund.
- **No finance background needed.** They train you from first principles. They want drive, curiosity and how you think - not memorised textbook answers.
- **The ladder:** Junior Analyst → Senior Analyst → Director. You'd join as a Junior Analyst in a sector team.
- **Its values:** Ownership, Ambition, Knowledge Transfer. Weave these words into your answers.

Who is likely to interview you

The email came from **Ray Martin** - Oakwood's **Director of Portfolio Management** for 2026-27 (he oversees what the fund actually holds). Questions go to **Alex Caesar-Giles** - the **Managing Director**, who is also Vice-President & Treasurer of the UEA Finance & Investment Society. The other directors are Aran Titus (Operations) and Sayeb Salam (Quantitative Operations).

Why this matters: a portfolio director will love it if you can talk about a stock or market you follow, and what you would do with the money.

SECTION 2

What is a student investment fund?

Zero-knowledge version first. Then the jargon.

Start with the basics

A **share** (or **stock/equity**) is a tiny slice of ownership in a company. If you own an Apple share and Apple grows and earns more, your slice is usually worth more. An **investment fund** is a pot of money that a team manages - they decide which shares to buy, how much of each, and when to sell. Professional funds (e.g. Schroders, Legal & General, BlackRock) manage billions for pension savers and the public.

A **student investment fund** is the same idea at a small scale, run by students. The money is real, so mistakes and good calls are real - which is the whole point: it's the closest thing to the job you can do while still at university.

How a decision gets made at Oakwood



Jargon buster

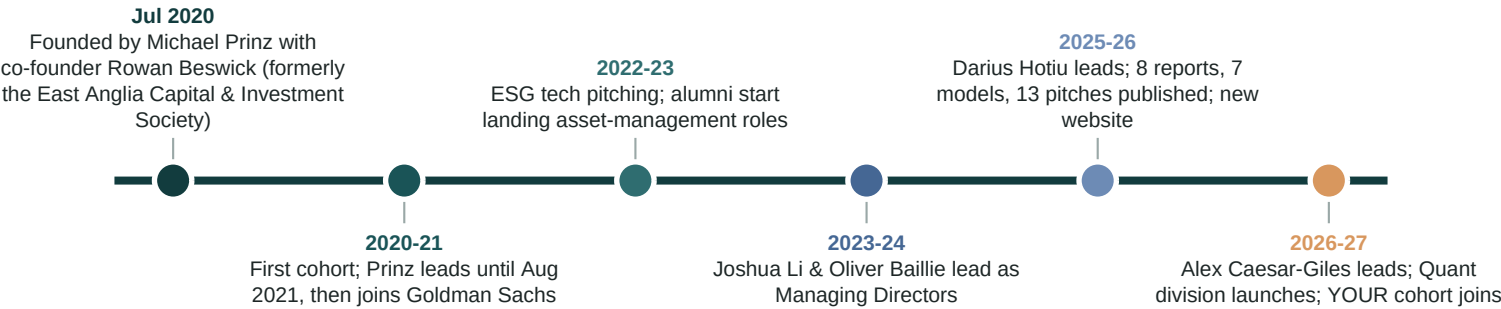
Term	Plain English
Long-only	The fund only buys shares hoping they rise. It never bets on prices falling ("shorting").
Portfolio / holdings	The full list of things the fund owns. Oakwood has ~38 holdings.
Sector	A group of similar companies, e.g. Healthcare = drug makers, hospitals, medical devices.
Stock pitch	A structured argument that a share is under- or over-priced, ending in Buy / Sell / Hold.
Industry report	A deep study of a whole sector - trends, risks, winners and losers (Oakwood's are ~20 pages).
DCF (Discounted Cash Flow)	Estimate all the cash a company will make in future, then convert it into what it's worth today.
Comparables ("comps")	Value a company by comparing it to similar ones, e.g. using the P/E ratio.
P/E ratio	Share price ÷ earnings per share. "How many years of profit am I paying for?"
Catalyst	A future event that could move the price - results day, a takeover, a new product, a rate cut.
ESG	Environmental, Social and Governance - judging companies on climate, people and how well they're run.
Sharpe ratio	Return earned per unit of risk (volatility). Higher = better reward for the bumpiness.
Benchmark	What you compare yourself to. Oakwood compares against the S&P 500 (top 500 US companies).

SECTION 3

History & structure

How long it has been going, who built it, and how it is organised today.

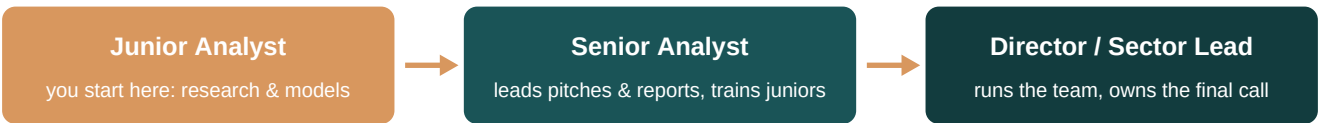
Six years of Oakwood



How Oakwood is structured



Inside every sector team, people climb a ladder (training + more responsibility at each step):

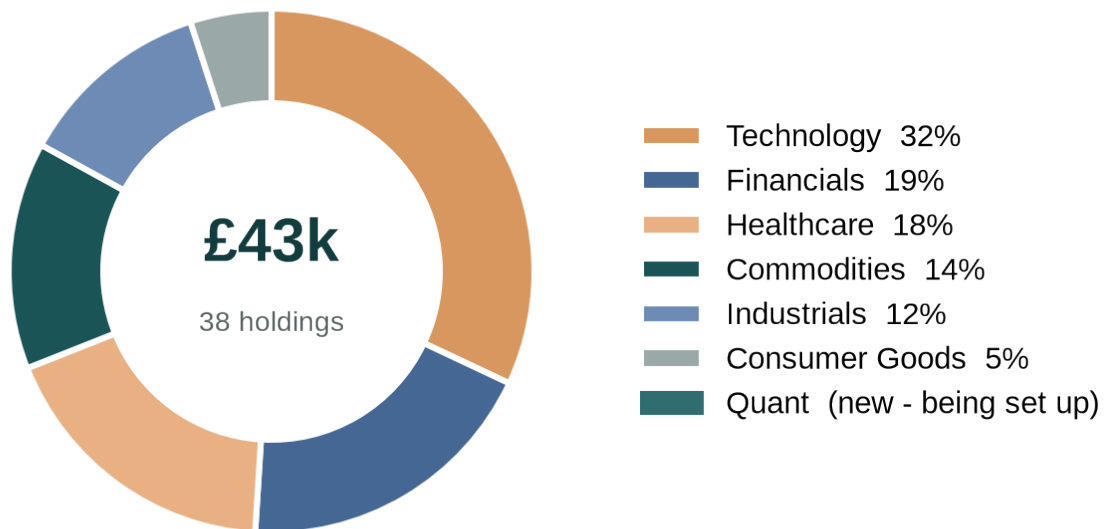


Part	What it does
Management team	Sets strategy, runs the research calendar, and is accountable for every deliverable the fund publishes.
Sector divisions (7)	Each owns its coverage end-to-end: screening names, building the models and defending the call.
Advisory committee	Former directors and founders who partner with each new cohort - this is how know-how passes on year to year ("Knowledge Transfer").
UEA Finance & Investment Society	The broader society (speaker events, commercial awareness sessions). Many Oakwood leaders have also run UEFIS.

SECTION 4

The money & the portfolio

How much the fund has, what it owns, and how it measures itself.



Sector weights as shown on oakwoodfund.uk (by current position size). Technology is the biggest slice - worth knowing if you're asked about the portfolio.

£43,440

Total position value quoted on the site (38 holdings built up by the 23/24, 24/25 and 25/26 cohorts)

~£40k

The figure the fund has quoted publicly before - so the pot has grown modestly over time

US-heavy

Mostly NASDAQ & NYSE shares, plus some European names; benchmarked against the S&P; 500

How they measure performance

Oakwood keeps a performance workbook that takes daily closing prices for every holding and turns them into returns, volatility and a **rolling one-year Sharpe ratio** for each stock, compared with the S&P 500. In plain English: *"Are our picks paying us enough for the risk we're taking - and are we beating just buying the index?"* They plan to publish a live holdings dashboard with position sizes.

Where does the money come from?

This is **not published** anywhere public. Student funds are usually seeded by the university, a donor/alumnus, or a business-school budget, and keep any gains. Don't guess in the interview - instead, it makes a **great question to ask them** (see Section 12). Asking it shows you think like a portfolio manager: "whose money is this, and what's our mandate?"

SECTION 5

Sponsors, partners & reputation

Honest version: here is what is - and isn't - publicly known.

Short answer on sponsors

Oakwood does **not publicly list a headline corporate sponsor** (no "Oakwood x Big Bank" deal on its website or LinkedIn). Its strength comes from its **people network** and a handful of partners. If they mention sponsors in the interview, listen and ask a follow-up - it's an area they may be building.

Name	Link to Oakwood	How to use it
Goldman Sachs	Founder Michael Prinz is a Family Office Associate at GS in London. The "most famous name" connected to the fund.	"Oakwood's founder went from here to Goldman - that shows what the platform can do."
McKinsey & Company	Co-founder Rowan Beswick is now a Junior Associate there (after 3 years at Deloitte).	Shows paths beyond banking - consulting.
Wall Street Oasis (WSO)	Oakwood hosted a Q&A with WSO's CEO Patrick Curtis; WSO is listed as a partner.	Big finance-careers platform - a sign of the fund's reach.
AmplifyME	Finance-training firm listed among partners; 2025-26 MD Darius Hotiu was a researcher on its 'Market Maker' podcast.	Trading simulations / training access.
Congrapps	Listed as a partner in public listings (careers/applications platform).	Recruitment and application support.
Norwich Business School	UEA professors have judged Oakwood's stock-pitch competitions.	Academic credibility for pitches.
CISI / CFA	Leaders hold CISI & CFA scholarships/credentials (e.g. Darius Hotiu, Michael Prinz).	Shows the professional-qualification culture.

Reputation - what it actually rests on

Track record 6 years running, 79+ pieces of published research you can read on their Insights page	Alumni 42 firms: Goldman Sachs, J.P. Morgan, Citi, Barclays, Deutsche Bank, Schroders, PwC, HM Treasury	Network ~1,000 LinkedIn followers; advisory committee in London, Cambridge & Hong Kong
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Why it matters for UEA: UEA isn't one of the traditional "target" universities that big banks recruit heavily from. A serious student fund closes that gap - it gives UEA students real deliverables, real stories for interviews, and alumni already inside the firms. That's why Oakwood leans so hard on professional standards: the fund's reputation *is* its members' CV credibility.

SECTION 6

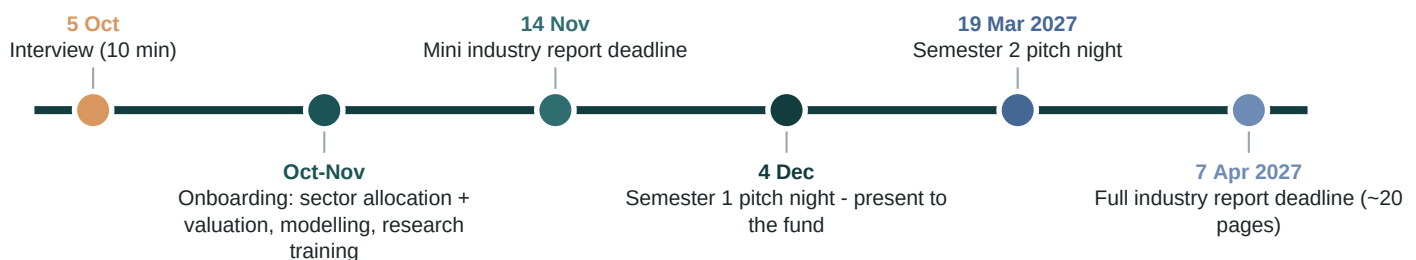
What you'd actually do

Pitching stocks is the activity. Here's what a pitch contains and what the year looks like.

Anatomy of an Oakwood stock pitch

1	Company overview	What does the firm do? Where does it sit in its industry?
2	Investment thesis	2-3 core reasons the stock is under- or over-valued.
3	Valuation	DCF, comparables, multiples, precedent transactions.
4	Catalysts	Upcoming events that could move the price towards your target.
5	Risks & mitigants	What could go wrong - and why the thesis still stands.
6	Recommendation	Clear Buy / Sell / Hold, position size, stop-loss conditions.

Your year if you get in



Dates from the fund's own website calendar. Time commitment: "a few hours per week during term", busier before pitch nights and report deadlines.

What Oakwood pitched last year (2025-26) - name-drop one of these

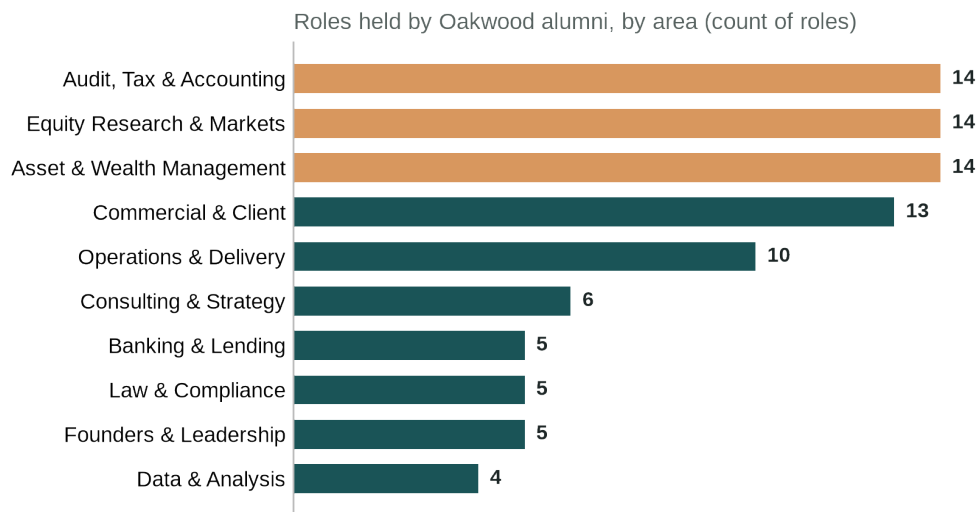
Sector team	Companies pitched / modelled in 2025-26
Technology	Twilio (cloud communications software)
Financials	Aviva (UK insurer), Paragon Banking Group (UK specialist lender)
Healthcare	McKesson (US drug distributor), GE HealthCare (medical imaging), Tonix (biotech)
Commodities	Boliden (Swedish metals miner), Neste (Finnish renewable fuels)
Industrials	ABB (Swiss automation/electrification), AECOM (infrastructure engineering), Masco (home products)
Consumer Goods	Nike (sportswear), Deckers Outdoor (HOKA & UGG brands)

Source: Oakwood Insights research library. Looking at one of these before Monday and having a view is a strong signal of genuine interest.

SECTION 7

Where people go after Oakwood

The proof that the fund works - and the answer to "what will this do for me?"



Selected firms alumni have joined

Goldman Sachs	J.P. Morgan	Citi	Barclays	Deutsche Bank	McKinsey	Deloitte
PwC	Accenture	Schroders Greencoat	Polar Capital	Legal & General	Aviva Investors	Rothsay
Northern Trust	NatWest	Lloyds	Marex	Charles Stanley	Baker McKenzie	HM Treasury
Dept. for Business & Trade	Hiscox	Centrica	Drax	Third Bridge	Alantra	Forvis Mazars

The advisory committee - real people, real paths

Name (Oakwood role)	Now	UEA degree / note
Michael Prinz (Founder, 20-21)	Goldman Sachs, London - Family Office Associate	Accounting & Finance, First; CFA Level II candidate
Rowan Beswick (Co-founder, 20-21)	McKinsey & Company, London (ex-Deloitte)	Master's in Mathematics, First
Joe Bartley (Senior Analyst, 22-23)	Charles Stanley - Junior Portfolio Manager (~£900m team)	Business Management; CISI diploma
Joshua Li (MD, 23-24)	Business Analyst in Hong Kong; founded an AI start-up	Law (LLB)
Oliver Baillie (MD, 24-25)	Mercor, London - Project Manager	Law internships at Clifford Chance, Jones Day
Jake Smith (Director, 24-25)	Deloitte, Cambridge - M&A Tax	Also ran UEAFIS as President
Darius Hotiu (MD, 25-26)	Deloitte M&A Tax intern; started as a Junior Analyst in Jan 2024	Accounting & Finance, First (79.4%)

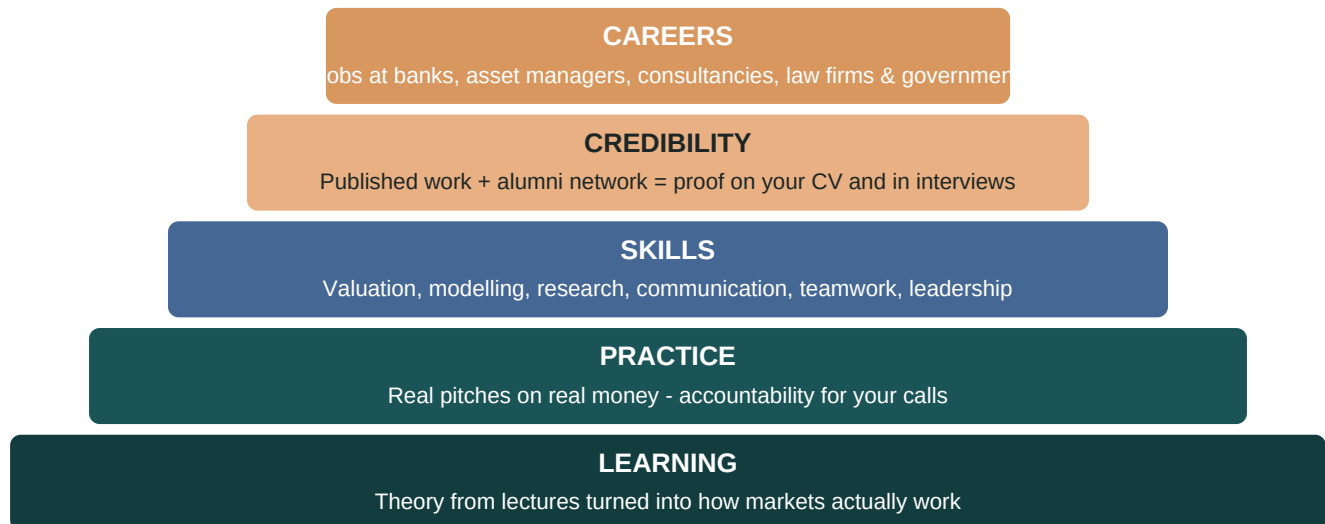
Notice: two of the last few leaders studied **Law**, one **Maths**. You don't need to be a finance student. And Darius went from Junior Analyst to running the fund in under two years - that's the ladder you'd be joining.

SECTION 8

The core purpose: why pitch stocks at all?

You asked: "we pitch stocks, but what's the goal of doing that?" Here's the answer.

The money is the training tool, not the end goal. Oakwood exists to turn UEA students into people who can think, work and talk like investment professionals. Each layer builds on the one below:



Who benefits	What they get
You (the student)	Hands-on finance experience, published research for your CV, technical skills, a network of alumni in the industry, leadership roles.
UEA	Bridges the gap between theory and practice; helps a non-"target" university compete for top finance jobs; strengthens graduate outcomes.
The fund itself	Each cohort passes knowledge to the next (advisory committee), so standards rise every year - their "Ambition" value.
Wider world (ESG)	Its ESG roots mean thinking about whether companies are well-run and sustainable - not just profitable.

"Ultimately, stock pitches are a bridge between theory and practice, allowing students to begin thinking like an investor. These skills are transferable to other professional industries like law, insurance and professional services."

- Oakwood Fund Management website

SECTION 9

The interview, decoded

Reading between the lines of the email - what they are really testing.

What the email says	What it really means	What to do
"We want you, we don't want practiced answers"	They'll spot a script instantly. They're testing authenticity and how you think on your feet.	Prepare stories and opinions , not sentences. Know your 3-4 talking points; say them naturally.
"Interest, spark and a real drive for learning"	Energy + curiosity matter more than knowledge. They train you, so they want someone who'll show up and grind.	Show you've already started: a stock you follow, a podcast, an Oakwood report you read.
"Clear commercial awareness"	Can you explain what's going on in markets and <i>why it matters to a business</i> ?	Have 1-2 current stories ready with a view (see Section 10).
"Mix of general finance and character questions"	Baseline technical literacy + would we enjoy working with you?	Learn the quick-fire answers (Section 11); be warm and specific.
10-minute slot	Probably 4-6 questions. ~1-1.5 minutes per answer.	Be concise. Answer first, then explain. Don't ramble.

Big clue from Oakwood's own website

Their "How to join" section describes the interview as: **"A conversational interview on motivation, a market you follow, and how you think."** So prepare exactly three things: **(1)** why you want this, **(2)** one market/stock/sector you genuinely follow, **(3)** a structured way of talking through a problem.

Q1 · Why Oakwood?

They're really asking: Have you understood what we are, and are you committed?

- Mention it's a **fund**, not a **society** - you want real accountability for real money.
- Name something specific: a 2025-26 pitch (e.g. Boliden, Aviva, Nike), the Quant division launching, or the alumni path (Darius: Junior Analyst → MD).
- Link to their values: **Ownership** (owning your call), **Ambition**, **Knowledge Transfer** (you'd want to pass it on later).
- Say which sector team you'd like and *why* - ties straight into the fund's structure.

Shape of an answer: *"I want to be held accountable for an investment view, not just learn about it in lectures. Oakwood is a fund, not a society - the pitches go into a real £40k-plus portfolio. I read [X] from last year and I'd like to join the [sector] team because..."*

Q2 · Your interests

They're really asking: Are you a real person with curiosity? Is there spark?

- Pick 1-2 genuine interests - finance or not - and show **depth** (what you've learned, done or built).
- Bridge it to investing if natural: sport → the business of football clubs; gaming → Nintendo/Sony; tech → AI chip demand.
- Avoid generic answers ("I like reading and travelling"). Specific beats impressive.

Shape of an answer: *"Outside my degree I'm really into [X]. What got me hooked on markets was realising [specific moment]..."*

Q3 · Commercial awareness

They're really asking: Do you follow the news and can you explain why it matters?

- Use the 4-step method: **What happened** → **Why** → **Who wins / who loses** → **What I'd do as an investor**.
- Link the story to an Oakwood sector team - that's the fund's actual way of thinking.
- Have a view, but show you understand the risks to it.

Shape of an answer: *"The big story right now is UK borrowing costs - the 30-year gilt touched 6%, highest since 1998. It's happening because... The losers are... As an investor I'd..."*

Q4 · General finance + character

They're really asking: Baseline literacy, honesty, and would we want you on our team?

- If you don't know: say so, then reason it out out loud. That's "how you think" - it scores well.
- Character: use short STAR stories (Situation, Task, Action, Result) about teamwork, a setback, a deadline.
- Show coachability: "here's what I'd learn and how".

Shape of an answer: *"I'm not 100% sure, but my instinct is... because if rates go up, then..."*

The 4-step commercial awareness formula (use it for any story)

1. What happened? One sentence, with a number. **2. Why?** The cause. **3. Who wins / who loses?** Name companies or sectors. **4. So what for us?** What would you do with Oakwood's money - buy, sell, hold, or watch for a catalyst?

Also prepare "a market you follow": pick ONE company you like and know what it sells, its latest results and one big risk.

SECTION 10

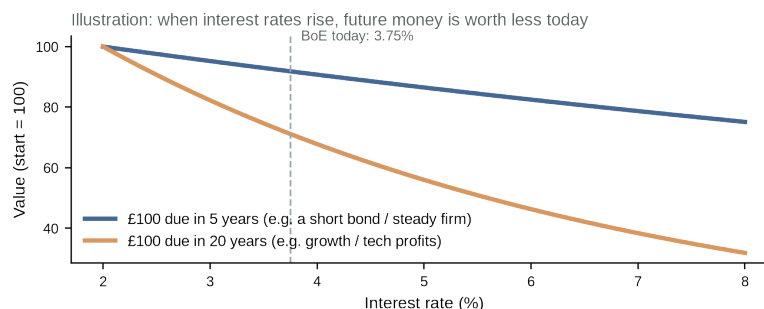
Commercial awareness pack

Market snapshot as of the weekend before your interview. Check the headlines again on Monday morning.

3.75% Bank of England rate - held 6-3 on 17 Sep; three members wanted a hike to 4%. Next decision 5 Nov	3.1% UK CPI inflation (Aug), above the 2% target; BoE expects ~3.75% by year-end	6.0% 30-year gilt yield touched 6% - highest since 1998. 10-year ~5.4%, highest in ~19 years
~\$100 Brent crude, after spiking to ~\$108 on Middle East / Strait of Hormuz tensions	~10,460 FTSE 100 - down ~2% last week; Thursday its worst day since May	Fed hike US Federal Reserve raised rates in September as services & energy inflation stays sticky

The one big story, explained simply

Energy shock → inflation → higher interest rates → higher borrowing costs. Conflict in the Middle East has pushed oil prices up. Expensive energy feeds into prices of almost everything, so inflation is rising again. Central banks fight inflation by keeping rates high (or raising them). Investors then demand more to lend to governments, so gilt (UK government bond) yields jump. That makes borrowing dearer for government, companies and mortgage holders - and makes shares look less attractive versus "safe" bonds. Growth/tech stocks get hit hardest, because most of their value is profit expected far in the future (chart below).



Link each story to an Oakwood sector team

Sector team	Current angle you could talk about	Winners / losers
Commodities	Oil ~\$100 on Hormuz risk; Oakwood pitched Neste (renewable fuels) and Boliden (metals).	Oil producers win; airlines, chemicals lose.
Financials	Higher rates can boost bank lending margins, but risk more bad loans; IG Group fell ~24% on a revenue-guidance cut.	Banks/insurers mixed; brokers volatile.
Technology	AI spending still huge, but high rates pressure valuations of long-duration growth stocks.	Profitable AI leaders vs unprofitable growth.
Industrials	Vesuvius +21% on a takeover bid from RHI Magnesita - M&A activity is a live theme.	Targets of bids win; cost pressures hurt.
Consumer Goods	Squeezed households if mortgages reprice higher; Wetherspoon +13% as guidance held up.	Value brands vs discretionary spending.
Healthcare	Defensive sector - people need medicine whatever the economy does; Oxford Nanopore +23%.	Defensives often hold up in sell-offs.

Figures from news reports for the week to 2 October 2026 (Bank of England, Corfe Capital FTSE weekly, market wires). Things move fast - re-check on Monday.

SECTION 11

Finance quick-fire & character questions

Short, honest answers. If you don't know - reason it out loud.

Likely question	A simple answer you can build on
What happens to bond prices when interest rates rise?	They fall. Existing bonds pay a fixed coupon, so when new bonds pay more, old ones must get cheaper to compete.
Why do rising rates hurt tech / growth stocks?	Their value relies on profits far in the future; higher rates discount that future cash more heavily.
What is a DCF?	Forecast a company's future free cash flows, discount them back to today at a rate reflecting risk, add them up = intrinsic value.
What is a P/E ratio?	Share price ÷ earnings per share. High P/E = market expects growth (or it's expensive); low = cheap or troubled.
How does the Bank of England fight inflation?	Raises Bank Rate - borrowing gets dearer, spending slows, price rises ease. Currently 3.75%.
Stock vs bond?	A stock is ownership (share of profits, no guarantee). A bond is a loan (fixed interest, paid back first).
Market cap vs enterprise value?	Market cap = share price × shares (equity only). EV = market cap + debt – cash: the price of the whole business.
What is ESG and does it matter?	Environmental, Social, Governance. Matters because poor governance or climate risk can destroy value - not just ethics.
How would you pitch a stock?	Overview → thesis (2-3 reasons) → valuation → catalysts → risks → Buy/Sell/Hold. (Oakwood's own structure!)
What's a Sharpe ratio?	Return above the risk-free rate, divided by volatility. Measures reward per unit of risk.
Where's the FTSE 100 / BoE rate?	FTSE ~10,460; BoE 3.75%; UK inflation 3.1%. (Check Monday.)

Character questions - and the Oakwood value each one tests

Question	What they look for	Value
Tell me about yourself.	60 seconds: who you are, what got you into markets, why now.	Ambition
Describe working in a team.	You split tasks, supported others, got to an agreed view - exactly what a sector team does.	Knowledge Transfer
Tell me about a mistake / setback.	You owned it, learned, changed something. Don't pick a fake weakness.	Ownership
How will you fit this around your degree?	Realism: "a few hours a week, more before pitch nights" - show a plan.	Ownership
Which sector team and why?	Real reason + a company you'd look at in that sector.	Ambition
Where do you see yourself in 3 years?	Progressing Junior → Senior → Director; a career direction you're exploring.	Ambition
What would you add to Oakwood?	A skill (Excel, coding for Quant, writing, presenting) or perspective from your degree.	Knowledge Transfer

SECTION 12

Questions to ask them + day-of checklist

Always have 1-2 questions ready. Good questions prove genuine interest.

Smart questions to ask (pick one or two)

- "Where does the fund's capital come from, and what's the mandate - is it still an ESG mandate?"
- "How does a pitch turn into a trade - does the whole fund vote, or does the portfolio director decide sizing?"
(perfect for Ray, as Director of Portfolio Management)
- "How is the new Quant division going to work alongside the fundamental sector teams?"
- "What separates Junior Analysts who progress to Senior from those who don't?"
- "How does the advisory committee get involved with new analysts during the year?"
- "Which holding in the current portfolio has taught the fund the most - good or bad?"

Your 3-point cheat sheet (fill this in tonight)

1. Why Oakwood (one line)	
2. A market / stock I follow + my view	
3. One current news story (4-step)	
4. The sector team I want + why	
5. My question for them	

Day-of checklist

- ☐ Book your 10-minute slot at cal.com/oakwoodfund/interviews (if you haven't already).
- ☐ Smart clothes. Arrive at New Sci 0.09 ~10 minutes before your slot.
- ☐ Skim BBC Business / FT / Bloomberg headlines on Monday - has the BoE, oil or gilt story moved?
- ☐ Re-read Section 1 and your cheat sheet. Glance at one Oakwood 2025-26 pitch on oakwoodfund.uk/insights.
- ☐ Answer first, then explain. Keep each answer to ~1 minute. Smile - it's conversational.
- ☐ If you don't know: "I'm not sure, but my thinking would be..." - then reason it out.
- ☐ Thank them; a short LinkedIn connect/thank-you afterwards is a nice touch.

They already said it: **"Don't stress... we want you."** You made it through a strong application round. Go in curious, specific and yourself.

Sources

- Oakwood Fund Management website - home, People, Portfolio and Insights pages, and site data files (oakwoodfund.uk), accessed 4 Oct 2026.
- Oakwood Fund LinkedIn company page (uk.linkedin.com/company/oakwood-fund) - founding, former name, WSO speaker event, NBS judging.
- Union of UEA Students - Finance & Investment Society page (ueasu.org) - UEAFIS committee, membership, Oakwood description.
- Bank of England - Monetary Policy Summary, September 2026 (bankofengland.co.uk).
- Corfe Capital, "This Week on the FTSE - 2 October 2026"; HomeOwners Alliance and James Sharp market news (Oct 2026).
- Partner names AmplifyME and Congrapps come from third-party search listings and weren't confirmed on Oakwood's own site.